



Beauty and the babes

Ford revealed the 2013 Mustang in a Sports Illustrated Swimsuit advert

Geek Life

movements. Even when wearing the HANS device, a driver's movement doesn't get hindered in any way.

It isn't heavy in any way, because this device is made of carbon fibre, kevlar, comfort padding and polyester straps. Different estimates give different figures, but the HANS device reduces the load on the neck by anywhere between 70 and 80 per cent. And that's the difference between life and sure death.

Initial apprehensions

Hubbard and Downing produced the first prototype of this device within one year of starting the project. However, despite its use in crash testing over the years, it wasn't until after Senna and Ratzenberger's deaths due to basilar skull fracture did Formula 1 teams sat up to take notice. By the late 90's even Mercedes F1 was doing the final stages of research on its HANS device. But interest started waning again, and not only the FIA, even authorities at Nascar, ChampCars and IRL weren't very interested. Probably exasperated, Dr. Hubbard went to a few races and offered these devices free of cost to any racer who would want to wear them. But a combination of ignorance, machoism and probably lack of self-preservation instincts ensured that this effort was in vain. The device went on the backburner again, for the next few years, until another life was lost.



In what was a very serious shunt in Montreal 2007, look at how Robert Kubica's head remains steady during multiple impacts.

HANS becomes mandatory, finally

February 18, 2001 at the Daytona 500, it was the last lap of the race. Dale Earnhardt, one of the "larger than life" figures in stock car racing in the States got dragged into a crash that started when two of his other colleagues tangled. Nascar had lost one of its icons, again due to the basilar skull fracture. In what was the deepest investigation of Nascar's safety in 50 years, it was found that Dale died almost instantaneously after his head hit the steering wheel.

After much debate and studying the device, authorities made the device mandatory in October 2001. FIA made this device mandatory in 2003.

Unfortunately, the motorsports world witnessed the death of Dan Wheldon at the Las Vegas Speedway, in a fiery crash, when his car flipped, and his head hit the fence. Just drives home the point that while danger will always be an integral part of motor racing, what matters is by how much extent we can remove that element. HANS takes care of one of those elements. 



The HANS system approved by Formula 1



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